

Password Reset & Account Recovery Guide

Document Version 2.0 | Last Updated: January 2024

1. Overview

This guide provides step-by-step instructions for resetting your password, recovering your account, and managing two-factor authentication (2FA). These procedures apply to all account types including Free, Pro, and Enterprise plans.

If you are unable to complete the password reset process using the methods below, please contact our support team at support@example.com or call +1-800-555-HELP (4357).

2. Standard Password Reset (Email Verification)

Follow these steps to reset your password via email verification:

1. Navigate to the login page at <https://app.example.com/login>
2. Click the "Forgot Password?" link below the password field
3. Enter the email address associated with your account
4. Click "Send Reset Link" - you will receive an email within 2-5 minutes
5. Check your inbox (and spam/junk folder) for the reset email from noreply@example.com
6. Click the "Reset Password" button in the email (link expires in 24 hours)
7. Enter your new password meeting the following requirements:
 - Minimum 12 characters
 - At least one uppercase letter (A-Z)
 - At least one lowercase letter (a-z)
 - At least one number (0-9)
 - At least one special character (!@#\$%^&*)
 - Cannot match your previous 5 passwords
8. Confirm the new password by entering it again
9. Click "Update Password" to complete the reset
10. You will be redirected to the login page. Sign in with your new password.

Important: The password reset link is single-use and expires after 24 hours. If the link has expired, you will need to request a new one by repeating the steps above.

3. Two-Factor Authentication (2FA) Recovery

If you have lost access to your authenticator app or device, follow these recovery procedures based on your available backup options.

Option A: Using Backup Recovery Codes

When you initially set up 2FA, you were provided with 10 one-time backup recovery codes. Each code can only be used once.

1. On the 2FA verification screen, click 'Use a recovery code instead'
2. Enter one of your unused backup recovery codes
3. After logging in, go to Settings > Security > Two-Factor Authentication
4. Disable and re-enable 2FA with your new authenticator device
5. Save the new set of backup codes in a secure location

Option B: SMS Backup Verification

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If you configured SMS as a backup 2FA method during setup:

1. On the 2FA verification screen, click 'Try another method'
2. Select 'Text message' option
3. A 6-digit code will be sent to your registered phone number
4. Enter the code within 10 minutes (codes expire after 10 minutes)
5. Once logged in, update your primary 2FA method

Option C: Identity Verification (Last Resort)

If you have lost access to both your authenticator and backup codes, you must verify your identity manually:

1. Send an email to security@example.com with subject '2FA Recovery Request'
2. Include your registered email address and account username
3. Attach a photo of a valid government-issued ID (passport, driver's license)
4. Our security team will verify your identity within 24-48 hours
5. Once verified, 2FA will be temporarily disabled on your account
6. Log in and set up 2FA again immediately

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4. Account Lockout Procedures

For security purposes, accounts are automatically locked after 5 consecutive failed login attempts. The lockout duration depends on the number of lockouts:

- First lockout: 15 minutes
- Second lockout: 30 minutes
- Third lockout: 1 hour
- Fourth lockout and beyond: 24 hours (contact support to unlock)

To unlock your account:

1. Wait for the lockout period to expire, then try again with the correct password
2. Alternatively, use the 'Forgot Password' flow to reset your password, which also unlocks the account
3. If you are locked out for 24 hours or more, contact support with your account email for manual unlock

5. Admin-Initiated Password Reset

Organization administrators can force a password reset for team members:

1. Log into the admin console at <https://admin.example.com>
2. Navigate to Users > Team Members
3. Search for the user by name or email
4. Click the user's profile > Security > 'Force Password Reset'
5. The user will receive an email with a mandatory password reset link
6. The user must reset their password within 72 hours or the link expires

Note: Admin-initiated resets are logged in the audit trail. The affected user receives a notification that their password was reset by an administrator.

6. Password Security Best Practices

- Use a unique password for each service - never reuse passwords
- Use a password manager (e.g., 1Password, LastPass, Bitwarden) to generate and store strong passwords
- Enable 2FA on all accounts that support it
- Never share your password via email, chat, or phone
- Be cautious of phishing emails asking you to reset your password
- Change your password immediately if you suspect it has been compromised
- Review your active sessions regularly: Settings > Security > Active Sessions

7. Frequently Asked Questions

Q: How often should I change my password?

A: Passwords expire every 90 days. You will receive a reminder 14 days before expiration.

Q: Can I use the same password again?

A: No. The system remembers your last 5 passwords and prevents reuse.

Q: What if I never received the reset email?

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A: Check your spam/junk folder first. If not there, verify the email address on file is correct. Corporate email servers may block our emails - ask your IT team to allowlist noreply@example.com. You can also try requesting the reset again after 5 minutes.

Q: Is there a way to reset without email access?

A: If you no longer have access to your registered email, contact support at support@example.com from any email with your account details and government ID for identity verification.